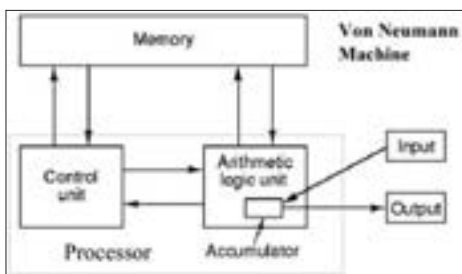


now). It was built on the design principles of what were later known as the von Neumann architecture. The first machine at Princeton served as a template for computers that were optimised for



The now-obvious von Neumann architecture

mathematical and scientific calculations in such fields as astronomy, meteorology, and hydrodynamics. These computers were used, for instance, in Los Alamos for computations that led to the design of the hydrogen bomb. Most of these computers were present in universities and research organisations; they were not designed for business users.

King Me

Arthur Samuels at IBM wrote the first game-playing program for checkers that was sufficiently skilled to play with a world champion. In 1955, the Samuel Checkers-playing program was the first program that learnt how to play, a significant milestone in the annals of AI.

November: Computer prediction

The UNIVAC cemented its place in the public mind-space when it correctly predicted the winner of the presidential poll in November between Dwight D Eisenhower and Adlai Stevenson. The expert opinion favoured a close race, while a UNIVAC borrowed by CBS predicted that Eisenhower would win by a landslide. CBS did not immediately release the results, but when the actual vote count came later, had to admit that the UNIVAC had only a 3 per cent margin of error. The term “Univac” became a generic name for computers; the 1953 IBM 701 was called IBM’s Univac.

November: The compiler

Rear Admiral Dr Grace Hopper, a pioneer in programming invented the first ever compiler—for the UNIVAC I, the A-O. She